Movecia



UNFOLD · MONTH 3 · WEEKS 9–13

Unfold

Taking the first steps

for .....

A LETTER FOR YOU

Hi lovely

Here we are in the third month of Unfold, and it makes me so happy that you're still here. In the first month you put down roots: you looked honestly at where you stand, made your mental load visible, understood why you sometimes feel so exhausted and used small routines to create more breathing space in your everyday life. In the second month your buds had room to grow, as you set boundaries, discovered your strengths, answered your inner critic kindly and finally gave your ideas some space.

This last month is called Unfold, and it's about getting started. You don't need a giant leap for this, or a perfect plan that you have to carry out flawlessly starting tomorrow. It's about the small, brave steps that carry an idea from your head into your life. Many of the women I work with have carried wonderful ideas inside them for years, always waiting until the children are older, until there's more time or until they finally feel ready. Over the next five weeks I would like to show you that you don't have to wait for that one right moment, because movement begins with you, right in the life you're living today.

Together we'll walk a five-week path in which each step builds on the last. First you'll choose, from your many ideas, the one that wants to come first and put it into one clear sentence. After that you'll learn how habits form in the brain and how to turn your plan into tiny steps that fit into your everyday life even on chaotic days. Week eleven is about courage and visibility, about understanding your fear better, asking for support and planning your first step out into the world. Week twelve belongs to self-compassion, because on every real path there are days when something doesn't work out. And in the final week we celebrate what has grown over these three months, and you walk into spring with a loving 90-day plan.

This month, too, the movement videos have been chosen very deliberately to accompany you. We begin with the video Finding balance, in which you stand on one leg and notice that wobbling is simply part of it, and we end with your closing flow and a small ritual for new beginnings that you can return to again and again, even after Unfold. As you practise, notice how much your body mirrors the themes of the week. Standing on the mat, we often grasp what courage, lightness or self-compassion really mean faster than we can with our heads.

Please treat this workbook as a companion who guides you through the month. You don't have to do every exercise or fill every line. Read at your own pace, take the pages that speak to you and leave the others for when their time comes. If a topic stirs you up a great deal, or you notice that your exhaustion or sadness isn't easing over a longer period, it's a sign of strength to seek additional support from your doctor or a therapist. Unfold can accompany you, but it doesn't replace professional treatment.

I'm so excited to see what will unfold for you over the coming weeks. Make yourself comfortable, put the kettle on, and then let's set off together. I'm walking every step with you. With love, Vivien

♡ Vivien

WHAT'S INSIDE

Week 9 · Clarity for your one idea
You assess your ideas honestly, choose the one that fits into your life right now and sum it up in a single sentence.

Week 10 · Small steps, real habits
You understand how habits form and use mini steps, habit stacking and if-then plans to build a routine that lasts.

Week 11 · Courage and visibility
You get to know your fear, climb your personal courage ladder, ask for support and plan your first step out into the world.

Week 12 · Self-compassion
You practise staying kind to yourself when something doesn't work out, and learn to see setbacks as a completely normal part of your path.

Week 13 · Celebrate and keep going
You look back on three months, celebrate every success and walk into spring with a 90-day plan and a farewell ritual.



TO BEGIN

How are you feeling as Month 3 begins?

Before we start on the new topics, take ten minutes for yourself and notice how you're really feeling today.

Two months are behind you, and perhaps a fair amount has already changed during that time, while other things are still exactly as they were in January. Both are fine. This little check-in helps you record honestly and without judgement where you stand right now, so that at the end of the month you can see what has shifted. For each statement, circle the number that feels truest today, and don't overthink it, because your first impulse is usually the most honest one.

How I'm feeling today

My energy in everyday life	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10
How restful my sleep is	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10
How light my head feels	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10
How clearly I know what I want	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10
How much I believe in myself	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10
How kindly I treat myself	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10
	hardly									very

My thoughts as we begin

What has changed in my everyday life or within me since I started Unfold, even if it's only something small?

Which idea from the second month has stayed on my mind ever since?

What do I wish for from this last month, and how will I know on 11 April that it was good for me?

My tip for you

Write today's date next to your check-in. In week thirteen you'll answer the same questions again, and it's a beautiful moment when you can then leaf back and see your own development in black and white.



WEEK 9

Clarity for your one idea

From many ideas, you choose the one that wants to come first. The others get a good place where they can wait for you.

When lots of ideas weigh you down rather than lift you up

Perhaps you know this feeling from last month: ever since you allowed your ideas to flow, there have been more and more of them. They're in your notebook, in the notes app on your phone, on little scraps of paper on the fridge, and many of them pop up precisely when you're trying to fall asleep. Each one feels like a small promise, like a door to a life that looks a little more like you. And yet something strange often happens as soon as things are meant to get concrete: instead of getting started, you suddenly feel tired, torn and a little overwhelmed.

That's not your fault, and it certainly doesn't mean you lack discipline. When we have to choose between a great many options, the decision becomes harder, we tend to put it off and afterwards we more often doubt the choice we made. On top of that, every open idea ties up a little piece of your attention. You already know this from week two, when we talked about mental load: everything left unfinished and circling in your head costs energy, even if it's something lovely. A woman who's already carrying the family calendar, the packed lunches for school, her job and her mother-in-law's birthday in her head simply doesn't have unlimited room for twelve passion projects at once.

Choosing one idea and keeping the others safe

Perhaps you feel a little resistance at the thought of committing to a single idea. Many women worry that with this choice they'll bury all their other dreams for ever. I would love to take that worry off your shoulders. This week you're choosing the idea that will get your attention for the next few months, and all the others move into what I call an idea park. This is a page of its own in your notebook where they're kept safe. They won't get lost there, but they won't weigh on you any more either, because you know where they are and that you can return to them at any time.

So making a choice is an act of caring for yourself. You give one idea your full strength instead of spreading your energy across many small beginnings that all peter out after a few weeks. And it often turns out later that the chosen idea naturally pulls the others along with it, because along the way you gather skills, contacts and self-confidence that help you with everything that follows.

What makes an idea the right one for now

The best idea is rarely the biggest or the most sensible. It's the idea that fits into your life as it is now, into exactly this phase of life with everything it's asking of you. That's why this week we look at your favourites through five questions. The first question is about joy: how alive do you feel when you think about this idea, and would you still want to pursue it if nobody ever found out about it? The second is about your time, that is, whether you can realistically free up one to three hours a week for it without your everyday life falling apart.

The third question concerns your energy. Some ideas give us strength as soon as we engage with them; others tend to drain it, because they're tied up with pressure, comparison or old expectations. The fourth question is money, in both directions, because it's about what the idea costs at the start and whether it should, or is allowed to, earn you something later. The fifth question is your gut feeling, that quiet, often very clear voice that speaks up before your head has sorted out all the arguments. None of these questions decides things on its own. Together, though, they paint a surprisingly honest picture.

Please rate them based on your real life, not on the life you would like to have. If you currently have a toddler who still wakes at night, or if an intense phase is coming up at work, you're allowed to factor that in. An idea that suits your phase of life is far more likely to grow than one for which you would have to rebuild your whole life.

Clarity also comes from the body

In this week's Full Day video, Finding balance, you stand on one leg, strengthen your feet and look for an inner calm, even though the ground beneath you seems to be constantly moving. You'll notice that you never stand completely still. Your body makes countless small balancing movements, and it's precisely these movements that keep you in balance. Decisions work in a very similar way. You don't have to be one hundred per cent sure in order to choose an idea. You're allowed to wobble, readjust and still stay standing.

The Tired Day video, Becoming light, is meant for evenings when your head feels heavy and full. Light, swinging movement while standing helps many women step off the merry-go-round of their thoughts. Feel free to try doing your idea exercises right after this short video. It's often much easier then to listen to your gut feeling, because your body has settled a little and your inner voice is no longer drowned out by the noise of the day.

Your idea in a single sentence

At the end of this week there will be a single sentence that describes your idea. That may not sound like much, but it's one of the most powerful tools I know. A clear sentence forces you to filter out what's essential, it gives you direction on days when you have doubts, and it makes it much easier in week eleven to tell others about your plan. A helpful structure is: I would like to create something particular for a particular person or for myself, because it matters to me for a particular reason, and I will begin with a first small step.

An example might sound like this: I would like to offer a small creative evening for women in my village, because I long so much for a community in which we can simply be creative, and I will begin by inviting three friends to a trial evening. Another example: I would like to write my children's book for twenty minutes every morning, because this story has been living inside me for years, and I will begin by setting up a corner of the kitchen table for it. Your sentence may sound completely different. All that matters is that you recognise yourself in it and that it brings a little smile to your face when you read it aloud.

GOOD TO KNOW

Too much choice can slow you down

Decision research shows again and again that when people have a great many options, they tend to hesitate and are sometimes less satisfied with their decision afterwards. How strong this effect is depends on the situation. For you, in very practical terms, this means: if you first narrow your ideas down to three to five favourites and then assess them, the choice becomes noticeably easier.

GOOD TO KNOW

A plan calms the mind

Unfinished tasks have a habit of pushing their way into our thoughts again and again. Studies by the psychologists E. J. Masicampo and Roy Baumeister suggest that simply settling on a concrete plan can considerably reduce this circling, even before the task itself is done. So writing your ideas into the idea park and setting a first step for your chosen idea really does take a load off your mind.

GOOD TO KNOW

Gut feeling is gathered experience

Intuition isn't magic. Experts such as the psychologist Gerd Gigerenzer describe it as a form of experiential knowledge in which our brain recognises patterns in a flash that we can't yet consciously name. That's why your gut feeling deserves a firm place in your decision, ideally alongside an honest look at time, energy and money.

Idea inventory

15 minutes

Before you assess anything, you gather all your ideas from your head and from last month's notes in one place.

1. Take a large sheet of paper or a double page in your notebook and write down every single idea that has come to you in recent weeks, including the very small ones and those that seem a little crazy.
2. Read through the list slowly, and for each idea place your hand on your belly for a moment. Notice whether something opens up, grows warm or tightens.
3. Mark the three to five ideas where you felt the clearest yes. These are your favourites for the assessment on the next page.
4. Write all the other ideas on a separate page headed My idea park and date them. They're kept safe there and can wait for you.

My idea assessment

Idea	Joy	Time	Energy	Money	Gut feeling	Total

Give each of your favourites a score from 1 to 5 in every column. For joy, energy and gut feeling, 5 means the idea fulfils you deeply. For time and money, 5 means it fits well into your current life and your budget. At the end, add up the total. The number is a guide, not a verdict. If an idea with a lower total still makes your heart beat faster, take that seriously and ask yourself which hurdle you might be able to make smaller.

The future test

10 minutes

With this little visualisation you test your two strongest ideas with your whole body rather than only with your mind.

1. Sit comfortably, place both feet on the floor and take three calm breaths in which you breathe out a little longer than you breathe in.
2. Imagine it's a year later, and you've chosen the first idea and stuck with it. What does a perfectly ordinary Tuesday in your life look like, what are you doing, how does your body feel?
3. Open your eyes and note down in two or three sentences what you saw and felt.
4. Repeat the visualisation with the second idea and note your impressions here too.
5. Compare your two sets of notes and ask yourself which version made you feel freer, more alive or simply more like yourself.

My tip for you

If you're torn between two ideas, toss a coin and assign one idea to each side. The point isn't to follow the result. Pay close attention to the moment the coin is in the air and to how you feel when it lands. Relief or a little pang of disappointment often tells you in a second what you have long been wishing for.

My decision questions

Which idea would I choose if I knew for certain that I couldn't fail?

Which idea would I pursue even if nobody found out about it and nobody praised me for it?

Which idea mainly makes me feel pressure, duty or other people's expectations, and what does that tell me?

What would I need to leave out or hand over in my everyday life to make room for my favourite?

What am I most afraid of with my favourite idea, and is this fear a reason not to choose it, or rather a sign that it matters to me?

My idea in one sentence

10 minutes

Now you put your chosen idea in a nutshell. Feel free to write several versions until one feels right.

1. Begin with the words I would like to and describe what you want to create, learn or change.
2. Add who you're doing it for: yourself, your family or other women.
3. Write down why it matters to you. The why will carry you on tough days.
4. Finish with the first small step you can take within the next seven days.
5. Read your sentence out loud. If it feels too big, too tame or too foreign, change individual words until it sounds like you.

My idea in one sentence

My first step this week

What exactly?	When?	How much time?	Done on

I'm allowed to choose one idea without losing my other dreams. They're waiting for me, and this one gets to grow now.

Looking back on week 9

How did it feel to commit to a single idea?

What did practising balance teach me about myself and the way I make decisions?

Who could I read my sentence to first?



WEEK 10

Small steps, real habits

You discover how an intention becomes a habit that lasts, and you give your idea a small, fixed place in your everyday life.

Why good intentions so often fizzle out

Last week you chose an idea, and perhaps you've even taken your first small step. That's wonderful, and now comes the real art: keeping going when the first excitement fades, when a child gets ill, when your job demands a lot of you or when you're simply tired. Most of us know the pattern from many Januaries: we take on something new full of enthusiasm, start ambitiously, and after two or three weeks the resolution has quietly disappeared. What's often left behind is the uncomfortable feeling of having failed to stick with it yet again.

I want to tell you today that this pattern says very little about your character. It arises mainly because we almost always rely on motivation and willpower, and both naturally fluctuate from day to day. Women with a heavy mental load in particular use up their willpower on a hundred small decisions long before they finally have time for themselves in the evening. A habit, on the other hand, needs hardly any willpower. It runs almost by itself, like brushing your teeth or reaching for the coffee machine in the morning. That's exactly what we want to achieve for your idea.

How habits form in the brain

A habit follows a simple loop that you have surely observed in yourself. It begins with a cue, that is, a situation, a time of day, a place, a feeling or a preceding action. Then comes the action itself, and at the end there's a reward, some pleasant feeling that your brain remembers. When this loop runs often enough in the same context, your brain links cue and action ever more closely, until the action happens almost automatically. Experts then speak of automaticity.

Take your phone in the evening as an example. The cue might be the moment when the children are finally asleep and you sit down on the sofa. The action is scrolling, and the reward is a brief feeling of relaxation and distraction after a full day. Your brain has experienced this sequence so often that your hand is already reaching for the phone before you've even thought about it. That's neither good nor bad; it simply shows you how powerful this mechanism is. Once we understand it, we can use it consciously for what truly matters to us.

Start small, really small

The most important principle this week is: make your step so small that you can manage it even on your worst day. The behaviour scientist BJ Fogg of Stanford University recommends starting new habits with a tiny version that takes less than two minutes. Instead of resolving to work on your project for an hour every day, you open your notebook every morning and write a single sentence. Instead of planning a complete website straight away, today you look for just one single page you like. That sounds almost ridiculously little, and that's exactly where its power lies.

A tiny step gets around your inner resistance. Your nervous system doesn't perceive it as a threat or as overwhelming, and day by day you collect small experiences of success. Often the one sentence turns into half a page all by itself, because you've already made a start. If not, that's completely fine too, because you have still strengthened the loop. In the first few weeks it's far more about anchoring the habit than about getting a lot done.

Habit stacking: linking new habits to old ones

One of the simplest ways to find a good cue is so-called habit stacking. You attach your new habit directly to a habit that's already firmly anchored in your day. The formula is: after I do a particular familiar action, I do my mini step. For example: after I pour my first cup of tea in the morning, I write one sentence for my project. Or: after I drop the children at nursery, I listen to ten minutes of a podcast on my topic on the way home.

The advantage is that you don't have to remember a new time and you're not waiting for the perfect moment. Your everyday life already provides the cues. Just make sure that the old habit really does happen daily and reliably, and that your mini step is actually practical at that moment. A step that requires you to sit at your laptop doesn't pair well with brushing your teeth, but it pairs very well with the moment you sit down at your desk after lunch.

If-then plans for difficult days

Even the loveliest habit will be put to the test, and it helps to prepare for that rather than hoping things will be different this time. This is where the if-then plans researched by the psychologist Peter Gollwitzer come in. You think in advance about which obstacles are likely to arise and decide how you'll respond. If a child is ill and I have no quiet time in the morning, then I'll write my sentence in bed in the evening. If I'm too tired for the Full Day video, then I'll do the Tired Day video or five minutes of Child’s Pose and breathing. That way your brain already has an answer ready when the difficult moment comes.

Movement as a mirror of your habit

This week's Full Day video is called Flowing instead of functioning. It's one continuous flow in which yoga, strength and free movement merge into one another. I designed it this way on purpose, because it shows exactly what we want to achieve with habits: one movement leads quite naturally to the next, without you having to think it through and push yourself every single time. In the Tired Day video, Freeing your hips, you hold longer poses such as Lizard and Garland. Many women find that when they hold these hip poses for a long time, something lets go on the inside as well. Perhaps after this video you would like to take a few minutes to write down which old habits you would actually like to let go of.

And one more thing: the two videos each week are themselves a wonderful practice habit. If you've done them rather irregularly so far, use this week to give them a fixed place with habit stacking and an if-then plan. You'll notice how much easier it feels when you don't have to decide afresh every time.

GOOD TO KNOW

66 days on average, and missing a day is allowed

In a well-known study from University College London led by Phillippa Lally, it took on average around 66 days for a new everyday action to feel automatic. The range, however, was huge, from 18 to more than 200 days, depending on the person and the habit. Especially comforting: missing a single day had no measurable effect on whether the habit still became established.

GOOD TO KNOW

If-then plans work

A review by Peter Gollwitzer and Paschal Sheeran, which brought together almost a hundred studies, concluded that concrete if-then plans considerably increase the likelihood of actually following through on a plan. The reason is probably that the situation itself becomes the cue, so that at the crucial moment you no longer have to weigh things up for long.

GOOD TO KNOW

Your brain learns through good feelings

Habits take hold especially well when a pleasant feeling follows straight after the action. A reward that only comes months later is too far away for your brain. That's why it's worth celebrating every mini step a little straight away, with a smile, a tick in your tracker or a conscious breath in which you tell yourself that you did it.

Decoding an old habit

10 minutes

Before you build a new habit, you take a closer look at an existing one. That way you understand the loop using your own example.

1. Choose a habit you would like to change, such as scrolling in the evening, snacking in the afternoon or putting off your own projects.
2. Write down what the cue is. When, where, after which action and in what mood does it usually happen?
3. Describe the action as precisely as possible, without judging it.
4. Ask yourself honestly what reward you're getting from it. Is it calm, distraction, comfort, connection or a little break from just keeping everything running?
5. Consider which other action could give you a similar reward. You can use this insight later for an if-then plan.

My habit loop

	Old habit	New habit
Cue		
Action		
Reward		
How I feel afterwards		



Finding your mini step

10 minutes

You shrink the first step of your idea until it seems almost too small.

1. Write down what you would like to do regularly for your idea, just as it comes to mind.
2. Ask yourself what half of that would look like, and write this smaller version underneath.
3. Halve it again, and then again, until you arrive at a version that takes less than two minutes.
4. Check honestly whether you could manage this mini step even on a day with a sick child, little sleep and a full calendar. If not, make it even smaller.
5. Write your mini step in large letters on a note and put it somewhere you'll see it every day.

Habit stacking: my links

After I …	I will …	My small reward
have poured my first cup of tea in the morning,	write one sentence for my project in my notebook.	a conscious sip of tea and a smile
have put the children to bed,	do two minutes of breathing practice on the mat.	a tick in my tracker

My if-then plans

If (situation or obstacle) ...	then (my plan) ...
If a child is ill and the morning turns chaotic,	then I'll do my mini step in the evening before I switch off the light.
If I'm too tired for the Full Day video,	then I'll do the Tired Day video or five minutes of Child's Pose with calm breathing.
If I've missed a day,	then I'll start again with my mini step the next day, without any guilt.

My tip for you

Stick to the rule of never missing twice in a row. One day off is completely normal and doesn't harm your habit. On the second day, though, you come back, even if it's with the very smallest version of your step. That way you stop a pause from quietly turning into a goodbye.

My tip for you

Make starting easy by preparing your surroundings. Leave your yoga mat rolled out in the living room, put your notebook and a pen at your breakfast spot or save the page you're working on as the first bookmark in your browser. Every step you save yourself makes it more likely that you'll begin.

My habit tracker for week 10

	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
My mini step for my idea	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
Movement: video, walk or time at the stables	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
Two minutes of breathing or meditation	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
Five minutes of journaling	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
In bed on time	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
A moment just for me	○	○	○	○	○	○	○

Journal for week 10

Which habit in my life already runs completely automatically, and how did it come about back then?

What has kept me from sticking to my resolutions in the past, and what am I doing differently this time?

Which moment in my day is best suited as a cue for my mini step?

How would I like to reward myself when I've taken my step?

Who would I like to become through this new habit?

I don't have to get everything done today. My small step counts, and it counts a little more every day.



WEEK 11

Courage and visibility

You get to know your fear better, climb your courage ladder step by step, ask for support and dare to take your first step out into the world.

The moment things get real

As long as your idea lives only in your notebook, it's safe. Nobody can criticise it, nobody can laugh, and nobody can ask how it's coming along. At some point, though, the moment comes when an idea wants to go out into the world. Perhaps you would like to tell a friend about it, publish your first post on Instagram, put up a flyer at the village hall or sign up for a course. And it's exactly at this point that most women feel a whole host of uncomfortable sensations: a pounding heart, a queasy feeling in the stomach and suddenly a thousand reasons why now isn't the right time after all.

The first thing I want to tell you is that these feelings are completely normal and that they say nothing about whether you're suited to your idea. Almost every woman I know who has built something of her own knows this fear. Brave people feel it too; they have simply learnt to go ahead with it at their side.

Fear is an old protector

To understand why visibility can frighten us so much, it's worth looking at our nervous system. Over a very long time, our brain developed in small communities in which belonging to the group decided whether you survived. Anyone who was cast out was in great danger. To this day, our alarm system therefore reacts very sensitively to anything connected with judgement, rejection and the gaze of others. When you put yourself out there, your body may switch into a stress response, as if something truly vital were at stake.

So your fear wants to protect you. It means well, even if in this case it's exaggerating a little. Instead of fighting it, you can greet it kindly and tell it that you've heard it and will take a small step anyway. Perhaps you remember week seven and the inner critic. Fear is her close relative, and you can meet it in a very similar way, with curiosity and with warmth.

Especially in places where everyone knows everyone, the worry about what others will say is often particularly strong. What will the neighbours say, the parents from nursery, your former colleagues? It helps to remind yourself that most people are far more occupied with their own lives than we think, and that many of them secretly admire a woman who finds the courage to try something of her own.

Courage grows through experience

Many of us wait until we finally feel brave and ready before we dare to take a step. In most cases it actually works the other way round. The feeling of self-confidence comes from the experience of having managed something, and it grows with every small step you take despite your nerves. With each of these steps, your nervous system learns that the catastrophe it feared doesn't happen, and next time the reaction will already be a little weaker.

That's why this week we're working with a courage ladder. You start right at the bottom with a step that makes you just a little nervous, and from there you climb rung by rung. The lowest rung might be reading your sentence from week nine to your partner. A middle rung might be telling an acquaintance about it, and one of the top rungs might be your first public post or your first small offer. You decide how fast you climb, and you may stay on each rung for as long as it takes to feel good.

Becoming visible at your own pace

Becoming visible doesn't mean you have to share your whole life online. Above all, becoming visible means bringing your idea out of hiding and giving other people the chance to see it, support you or benefit from it. For one woman that's a conversation at a parents' evening, for another an Instagram profile, for a third a notice in the village shop. There's no right or wrong way, only the way that suits you and your idea.

In this week's Full Day video, Taking up space, you get to stretch out wide and take up space, quite deliberately. With wide poses such as Goddess, Warrior II and Triangle, with strong legs and movements that use the whole room, you experience in your body what it feels like to claim space for yourself. Whether poses like these measurably change anything about our hormones is a matter of debate in research. But many women tell me that afterwards they feel different: taller, more awake and a little more themselves. Try it out, perhaps even right before your first brave step this week.

The Tired Day video, Letting go in the evening, is your counterbalance. After a day on which you have shown yourself and left your comfort zone, your nervous system needs time to settle again. With Legs up the Wall and a gentle body scan, you give yourself exactly that. Courage and rest belong together, and the better you can calm yourself after an exciting step, the easier the next one becomes.

Asking for support

Many women, mothers especially, have learnt over the years to manage everything alone. Asking for help feels to them like admitting weakness or like a burden they don't want to put on others. Yet it's one of the most important skills on the way to an idea of your own. Nobody builds anything entirely alone. You might need someone to take the children on Saturday morning, a friend to read over your text or someone to remind you of your goals when you start to doubt.

A good request is concrete, friendly and leaves the other person free to say no. Instead of a vague sentence such as “You could support me a bit”, it's better to say: “I would like to take time for my project every Saturday from nine to eleven. Would you take the children out during that time?” The more clearly you say what you need, the easier it is for others to help you. And you'll probably be surprised by how gladly people offer their support once they know what it's about.

GOOD TO KNOW

The spotlight effect

In a well-known study by Thomas Gilovich and colleagues, students had to wear an eye-catching T-shirt and estimate how many people in the room had noticed it. They guessed around half; in reality it was only about a quarter. So we regularly overestimate how closely others are watching and judging us. That can reassure you as you take your first step out into the world.

GOOD TO KNOW

Excitement and fear are close physical relatives

A pounding heart, faster breathing and butterflies in your stomach belong to fear as well as to anticipation. The researcher Alison Wood Brooks found evidence that people performed better in test situations when they told themselves out loud beforehand that they were excited, rather than ordering themselves to calm down. So interpreting your state as excitement can help you use the energy rather than fight it.

GOOD TO KNOW

People are happier to help than we think

Studies by Francis Flynn and Vanessa Lake showed that people considerably underestimate how willing others are to help them when they ask directly. In their experiments, participants needed to approach only about half as many people as they had expected in order to get the support they wanted.

Getting to know my fear

15 minutes

With this exercise you bring your fear out of the fog and take a calm look at it. It often loses part of its power in the process.

1. Write down the step for your idea that frightens you most right now.
2. Note what could happen in the worst case, as concretely as possible.
3. Underneath, write what could happen in the best case, and allow yourself to dream a little as you do.
4. Now consider what's most likely to happen if you look at the situation honestly and realistically.
5. Finally, ask yourself how you would deal with the worst case if it did happen, and who or what could help you then.

My fear in the light of day

	My thoughts
The step I'm afraid of	
In the worst case	
In the best case	
Most likely	
If the worst case happens, I would	

My tip for you

If your heart pounds before a brave step, place a hand on your chest and say quietly to yourself: I'm excited because this matters to me. Then take two deep breaths into your belly, lengthening the exhale. This little moment helps many women experience the energy in their body as anticipation.

The courage ladder on the next page helps you break your path out into the world into small, manageable rungs. At the very bottom, enter the step that makes you least nervous, and at the very top the one that still feels biggest right now. For each rung, rate how nervous you are, and enter a date as soon as you've taken it. You can change the ladder at any time and add new rungs if a step seems too big.

My courage ladder

Rung	My step	Nerves (1–10)	By when?	Done on
8 · the biggest step				
7				
6				
5				
4				
3				
2				
1 · the smallest step				

Phrases that make asking easier

- “I have a project that's very close to my heart. May I tell you about it and hear your honest opinion?”
- “I would like to take two hours a week for my idea. Could you put the children to bed on Thursday evenings?”
- “You know so much about this topic. Would you have half an hour in the next few weeks for a coffee and a few questions?”
- “Would you read over my text? It's completely fine if you don't have time right now.”
- “I've decided to take my first step by the end of the month. Would you mind asking me in two weeks how it's going?”
- “I would be absolutely delighted if you shared my post or told a friend who might be interested.”



Wording my request

10 minutes

You choose one person and prepare a clear, friendly request.

1. Think about where you most urgently need support over the coming weeks, whether time, knowledge, encouragement or practical help.
2. Write down who could help you with it, and feel free to think of people you don't see every day.
3. Put your request into one or two sentences and make it as concrete as possible, with a time, a duration and the exact task.
4. Add a sentence that explicitly allows the other person to say no. That takes the pressure off both of you.
5. Decide when you'll make your request, and put it in your calendar.

Who can support me?

Person	What can they help me with?	My request	I'll ask by

My first step out into the world

Now things get concrete. Choose a step from the middle of your courage ladder, one that challenges you and that you can still take within the next two weeks. Plan it with the questions in the table so precisely that your mind can no longer find any gaps for excuses to creep through.

My plan for my first step out into the world

Question	My answer
What exactly will I do?	
When will I do it (day and time)?	
Where, or through which channel (in person, Instagram, notice, email)?	
Who will hear about it?	
What will I prepare beforehand?	
Who will support me?	
What will I do if the fear gets big right beforehand?	
How will I reward and calm myself afterwards?	

My tip for you

Tell a woman from our Unfold circle when you plan to take your step, and ask her to send you a short message on the day. Knowing that someone is thinking of you and rooting for you makes an incredible difference. And in the next live call we'll celebrate together how it went.

Journal for week 11

At which moments in my life have I already been brave, and what helped me back then?

Whose opinion do I fear most, and why does it matter so much to me?

What would I say to a friend who was about to take exactly the step I'm facing?

How did my body feel during Taking up space, and where in my everyday life would I like to take up more space?

What came easily when I asked for support, and what was hard?

I'm allowed to be seen. My idea deserves space, and I deserve support on my way.



WEEK 12

Self-compassion

On every real path there are days when something doesn't work out. This week you practise staying kind to yourself, especially then.

When something doesn't work out

Perhaps over the last few weeks you've made wonderful progress, taken your mini step every day and dared to take your first brave step out into the world. Or perhaps things went quite differently. The children were ill, work swallowed you up, your tracker stayed half empty, and hardly anyone reacted to your first post. Perhaps you made a request and got a no. And perhaps you're sitting there now, hearing that familiar voice telling you that you've failed yet again and might as well give up straight away.

I want you to know that weeks like this are absolutely part of every path. There's nobody who builds something new without stumbling again and again. The crucial difference lies in how we speak to ourselves when things don't go as planned. And that's exactly what this week is about: self-compassion, a skill you can learn and practise just like a yoga pose.

What self-compassion means

The American psychologist Kristin Neff, who has been researching this topic for many years, describes self-compassion through three building blocks. The first is kindness towards yourself. In a difficult moment you treat yourself as you would treat a good friend, with warmth and understanding instead of harsh criticism. The second building block is an awareness of our common humanity. You remind yourself that mistakes, weaknesses and setbacks are part of every person's life, and that you're not alone with your pain. The third building block is mindfulness, the ability to notice your feelings without pushing them away and without losing yourself in them completely.

Perhaps at this point an objection comes up that I hear very often: if I'm too nice to myself, I'll get comfortable and stop making an effort altogether. Research paints a different picture. Self-compassion doesn't mean giving up your standards or glossing over everything. People who treat themselves kindly are often even more motivated to try again after a failure, because they don't have to fear punishing themselves for every mistake. Harsh self-criticism, on the other hand, often leads us to avoid difficult things altogether, simply to escape that inner verdict.

Setbacks are part of the path

When you think of a path, you may picture a straight line climbing steadily upwards. Real development, though, looks more like a mountain trail. It winds, sometimes leads downhill for a stretch, demands detours and breaks, and yet with every step you come closer to the summit. So a setback is above all a sign that you're on a real path.

Do you remember the habit research from week ten? Missing a single day had no effect on whether a habit became established in the long run. What really does harm is the feeling of having failed and the thought

that nothing matters now anyway. Self-compassion is the very antidote to that thought. It allows you to pause briefly, acknowledge your pain and then gently get back up again.

Every setback also contains information. Perhaps your mini step was too big after all, perhaps the cue didn't work reliably, or perhaps you took on too much at a time when your life was already very full. When you look with kind eyes, you can learn something from every stumble and adjust your plan instead of questioning yourself.

Self-compassion begins in the body

In this week's Full Day video, Strength and softness, you deliberately alternate between effort and letting go. A Wall Sit is followed by shaking out, the Plank by Child's Pose, the Glute Bridges by gently releasing your knees. I chose this alternation because self-compassion works in exactly the same way. There are moments when you need your strength to keep going, and moments when you're allowed to soften and give yourself a break. Both belong together, and the better you can sense which one is needed right now, the more lovingly you can treat yourself.

In the Tired Day video, Arriving in gratitude, every area of your body receives attention and a thank you. This may feel a little unfamiliar at first. Many of us are used to looking at our body mainly with a critical eye, and we only rarely thank it for everything it does for us day after day. This little practice can be a beautiful way into more kindness towards yourself, and many women tell me that they sleep more peacefully afterwards.

Please take good care of yourself if you notice that difficult feelings become very big this week or stay with you over a longer period. Self-compassion can support you wonderfully, but it doesn't replace professional help. If sadness, exhaustion or self-doubt won't let go of you for weeks, please talk to your doctor or a psychotherapist. That too is an act of self-compassion.

GOOD TO KNOW

Kindness makes you more motivated

The psychologists Juliana Breines and Serena Chen of the University of California, Berkeley, asked participants to think about a personal mistake. Those who were guided to treat themselves with compassion were afterwards more motivated to improve and not to repeat the mistake than those who were mainly asked to boost their self-esteem.

GOOD TO KNOW

The three building blocks according to Kristin Neff

According to the researcher Kristin Neff, self-compassion consists of kindness towards yourself, the awareness that difficulties are part of our common humanity, and mindful awareness of your own feelings. You'll find these three building blocks again in the self-compassion break, which you'll get to know on the following pages.

GOOD TO KNOW

Soothing touch

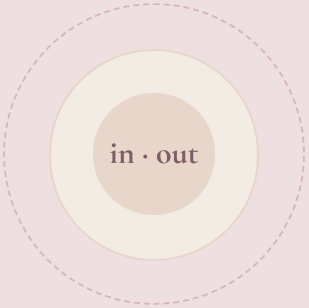
A hand on the heart, a hug or gently stroking the arms are gestures we instinctively use to comfort others. Early studies suggest that such touch can also have a calming effect when we give it to ourselves, for example by slightly dampening the body's stress response. Try out which gesture feels right for you.

The self-compassion break

5 minutes

This short practice goes back to Kristin Neff. You can do it anywhere, in the car, in the loo or in bed at night, whenever you notice that your heart feels heavy.

1. Think of a situation that's weighing on you right now, and notice where in your body you feel it, perhaps as tightness in your chest, pressure in your belly or heaviness in your shoulders.
2. Say quietly to yourself: This is a difficult moment. In doing so, you mindfully acknowledge that you're struggling.
3. Then say: Difficult moments are part of life, and many other women are feeling something very similar right now. This reminds you of our common humanity.
4. Place one or both hands on your heart or somewhere else where the touch feels comforting, and feel the warmth of your hands.
5. Finally, say: May I be kind to myself. If other words feel more fitting, ask yourself what you would like to hear right now, such as I'm here for myself or I'm allowed to make mistakes.



BREATHWORK

Breathing for a gentle moment

4 · 6

Breathe in calmly through your nose for a count of four and breathe out slowly through your nose or slightly parted lips for a count of six. An exhale that's a little longer than the inhale helps many people settle. Feel free to place one hand on your heart and one on your belly as you do, and repeat the cycle six to ten times. If the counts feel too long, simply shorten them; all that matters is that the exhale stays a little longer.

The kind setback check

15 minutes

When something hasn't worked out, this check helps you look at it with clear eyes and a warm heart, without judging yourself.

1. Describe factually what happened, just as a neutral observer would describe it.
2. Write down which feelings this situation stirs in you, and allow yourself to name them completely honestly.
3. Note what your inner critic says about it, and look at these sentences from a little distance.
4. Ask yourself what a loving friend would say to you in this situation, and write down her words.
5. Consider what you can learn from the situation and what you would like to do differently next time.
6. Decide on the smallest next step with which you'll start again, ideally today or tomorrow.

My setback check

Question	My answer
What happened?	
What am I feeling?	
What does my inner critic say?	
What would a loving friend say?	
What do I learn from it?	
My smallest next step	

My tip for you

Imagine your daughter or your best friend telling you about a setback just like yours. Would you tell her that she just can't do it? Certainly not. Speak to yourself in the same tone you would use with her. At first this may feel strange, but over time it becomes a soothing habit.

A letter to myself

This exercise is one of the most moving of the whole month. You write yourself a letter as if it came from a friend who loves you unconditionally, who knows all your strengths and weaknesses and knows exactly how much you've carried and achieved over the last few months. Choose a quiet moment for it, perhaps after the video Arriving in gratitude, light a candle and write without censoring yourself. Nobody but you will read this letter.

My letter to myself

20 minutes

These questions can help you as you write. You don't have to answer them all; simply take the ones that speak to you.

1. Begin with a loving greeting, just as you would wish to be addressed.
2. Write what this friend sees in you and admires, even if you find it hard to accept.
3. Describe what she thinks about the difficult moments of the last few weeks and how she sees you in them.
4. Write what she wishes for you for the coming months and what she would like to give you for the road ahead.
5. End the letter with a sentence you would like to read on hard days.

My letter to myself

Journal for week 12

How do I usually speak to myself when something goes wrong, and where have I heard this tone before?

Which setback in the last few weeks hurt me most, and what did it show me?

When have I comforted myself before, and how did that feel?

What would I like to thank my body for today?

What do I need in order to be kinder to myself on difficult days?

I'm allowed to stumble and still keep going. I stay by my own side, especially when things get hard.



WEEK 13

Celebrate and keep going

Together we look back on three months, celebrate everything that has grown, and you walk into spring with your plan and a lot of trust.

Three months that count

We've arrived in the last week of Unfold, and right now I'm feeling so many things at once. There's joy about everything that has grown in you over these weeks, a touch of wistfulness because our time together in this form is coming to an end, and a great curiosity about what you'll create next. When we started in January, it was still deep winter outside. Now it's getting lighter, the days are longer, and the first green is appearing. I find it beautiful that your path through Unfold has followed exactly this rhythm of nature, from resting to budding to unfolding.

This week is dedicated to celebrating and to keeping going. Both matter equally. If we only keep going without pausing, we all too easily overlook what we've already achieved. And if we only celebrate without looking ahead, we quickly lose the thread once a programme ends. That's why over the next few days you'll make time for both: for a loving look back and for a clear, achievable plan for the next 90 days.

Why celebrating isn't a luxury

Many of the women I work with find it hard to celebrate their own successes. They've learnt to be modest, to leave the recognition to others and to head straight for the next goal as soon as one is reached. Perhaps you also know that reflex of immediately waving away praise and saying it was nothing special. This week I would like to invite you to interrupt that reflex on purpose.

Our brain tends to notice negative things far more strongly and store them for longer than positive ones. Experts speak of a negativity bias, which probably once helped us not to overlook dangers. In everyday life, though, it means we remember every mistake and hardly notice our progress. When you consciously notice, write down and celebrate your successes, you balance out this bias to some extent. You strengthen your self-confidence, and you give your brain exactly the reward it needs to stick with your new habits.

Celebrating doesn't have to be anything big. It can be a special coffee at your favourite café, a walk entirely on your own, an evening with your best friend, a new notebook for your project or simply a moment in which you sit down, place your hand on your heart and tell yourself that you're proud of yourself. All that matters is that you experience the moment consciously and don't let it get lost in the bustle of everyday life.

Looking back with kind eyes

For your review, it's worth picking up the workbooks from the first two months again. Leaf slowly through your notes from Roots and Buds and read what you wrote back then. Perhaps you'll be amazed at how differently you would answer some questions today. Perhaps you'll also discover that some topics aren't yet finished, and that's perfectly fine. Growth isn't a project that's complete on a particular date; it stays with you for life.

In your review, please also pay attention to the small, quiet changes. Perhaps you haven't founded a company or published a book, but these days you say no more often without justifying yourself for hours. Perhaps you've discovered how soothing two minutes of breathing in the morning are for you, or for the first time in years you told a friend about your dream. It's often precisely these quiet changes that form the foundation for everything that becomes visible later.

What stays when Unfold ends

This week's Full Day video is called Unfolded: your closing flow. It brings together elements from all three months and ends with a quiet moment just for you. Perhaps you'll recognise movements in it that were still hard for you in January and now feel quite familiar. Take your time with this video, do it on a day when you're not rushed, and at the end feel free to stay in Savasana a little longer.

The Tired Day video, A ritual for new beginnings, is my gift to you for the time after Unfold. It's a short ritual of breath, movement and stillness that you can return to again and again, whenever you begin a new chapter, want to realign yourself or simply want to find your way back to yourself. You could, for example, plan it for the first day of every month, as a fixed appointment with yourself.

Besides the videos, you take so much more with you: your habits, your rituals of journaling, meditation and breathwork, your courage ladder, your letter to yourself and above all the experience that you can set something in motion step by step. And you take with you the women from our circle who have accompanied you on your way and who will surely be delighted to hear from you after 11 April too.

Your spring: the 90-day plan

Finally, we look ahead. A period of 90 days is ideal for moving an idea a good way forward. It's long enough to experience real progress and short enough to stay manageable rather than blurring into the distant future. Your plan takes you roughly from mid-April to mid-July, through the whole of spring and into summer.

Divide the 90 days into three stretches of about a month each. For each stretch, think about what you would like to achieve, which small steps will lead you there and who or what can support you along the way. Please plan generously and realistically. Think of holidays, bank holidays, birthdays and all the things that are coming your way in spring anyway. A plan that includes buffers carries you much further than a plan that only works on perfect days. And remember that your plan may be adjusted at any time if your life changes.

GOOD TO KNOW

The progress principle

The Harvard researcher Teresa Amabile, together with Steven Kramer, analysed thousands of diary entries from working people. They found that hardly anything lifted mood and motivation as much as the feeling of having made progress on a meaningful task, even when that progress was small. So consciously noticing your successes is a real source of strength for everything that still lies ahead of you.

GOOD TO KNOW

The peak-end rule

The psychologist and Nobel laureate Daniel Kahneman described how, looking back, we judge experiences mainly by their most intense moment and by their ending. So a conscious, lovely conclusion shapes to a large extent how you'll remember these three months later. That's exactly why it's worth ending Unfold with a small ritual.

GOOD TO KNOW

Planning in manageable stretches

In many studies, goals broken down into concrete intermediate steps with fixed dates are easier to achieve than vague resolutions for a whole year. A period of about three months feels manageable for many people while still leaving enough room for noticeable change.

My review of three months

30 minutes

Give yourself a quiet half hour for this review, along with your workbooks from Month 1 and Month 2.

1. Leaf through your Roots workbook and read your answers from the first check-in. Note what stands out to you.
2. Look at what you wrote about your mental load and your exhaustion, and ask yourself what has changed since.
3. Leaf through your Buds workbook and read your thoughts on boundaries, strengths, your inner critic and your ideas.
4. Read your check-in from the beginning of this month and compare it with how you feel today.
5. Write down the three moments in Unfold that touched or changed you most.

My review

Who was I when I started Unfold in January, and who am I today?

Which moment in these three months touched me most?

What have I learnt about myself that I never want to forget?

Which habit or ritual do I definitely want to keep?

My list of successes

Write down truly everything you've achieved, learnt, dared or changed over the last three months, including the things that seem small to you. A no you said counts just as much as a first post on Instagram, and an evening on which you consciously allowed yourself a break counts just as much as a finished project. Try to find at least twenty things. If you run out of ideas, ask your partner, a friend or the women from our circle what they've noticed in you.

My list of successes

No.	What I achieved, learnt or dared	How I felt
1		
2		
3		
4		
5		
6		
7		
8		
9		
10		
11		
12		
13		
14		
15		
16		
17		
18		
19		
20		



My tip for you

Start a success jar. It's a simple screw-top jar into which, from now on, you drop every small success on a folded slip of paper. On days when you doubt yourself, take out a few slips and read them. And at the end of the year you'll have a whole treasure trove of proof of how much you can set in motion. For me, a pot I've made myself is of course the loveliest choice, but any jar from your kitchen serves the purpose just as well.

Before and after

Do you remember your check-in at the beginning of this month? Now you'll answer the same questions again. First circle how you felt at the start of Unfold in January, as well as you can remember, and then how you feel today. If some scores have hardly changed, please be kind to yourself. Change takes time, and sometimes it only shows weeks later.

How I felt in January

My energy in everyday life	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10
How restful my sleep is	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10
How light my head feels	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10
How clearly I know what I want	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10
How much I believe in myself	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10
How kindly I treat myself	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10
	hardly									very

How I'm feeling today

My energy in everyday life	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10
How restful my sleep is	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10
How light my head feels	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10
How clearly I know what I want	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10
How much I believe in myself	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10
How kindly I treat myself	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10
	hardly									very

What I notice when I compare

Where do I see the biggest change, and what made it possible?

Where would I still like to grow, and how can I support myself in that over the coming months?

My 90-day plan for spring

Before you fill in the table, write your sentence from week nine once more at the very top. Does it still fit, or has it changed over the last few weeks? Feel free to adjust it if you've gained more clarity in the meantime. Then plan the three stretches of your spring.

My idea in one sentence, spring version

My 90-day plan

Stretch	My goal	My small steps	Support and resources	How I'll celebrate
Days 1–30 · April to May				
Days 31–60 · May to June				
Days 61–90 · June to July				

My habits for spring

Habit	Cue (after I ...)	My if-then plan for difficult days

My appointments with myself

- [ ] Ritual for new beginnings entered in my calendar for the first day of every month
- [ ] A fixed weekly slot for my idea entered in the family calendar
- [ ] Two movement sessions a week planned in
- [ ] Appointments on days 30, 60 and 90 for a short review entered
- [ ] Asked a woman from the Unfold circle whether we'll keep supporting each other
- [ ] My success jar set up

On the next page you'll find a weekly planner for your first week after Unfold. Enter your priorities, consciously plan in time for your idea and for your self-care, and remember that even a week with just one single small step is a good week.



PLANNER

My first week after Unfold

Mon

Tue

Wed

Thu

Fri

Sat

Sun

MY TOP THREE PRIORITIES

SOMETHING JUST FOR ME

A farewell ritual

To close, I invite you to a small ritual. Rituals help us shape transitions consciously, close a chapter lovingly and step into a new one with clarity. You can do it alone or together with a friend, and you can adapt it however feels right to you.

My farewell ritual for Unfold

30 minutes

Choose a quiet evening when you won't be disturbed. Have a candle, your workbook, a pen, a lovely sheet of paper and an envelope ready.

1. First do the video A ritual for new beginnings and come fully back to yourself through breath, movement and stillness.
2. Light the candle and slowly read your letter to yourself from week twelve once more.
3. On one sheet, write what you would like to leave behind from these three months, for example an old belief, a fear or a habit that no longer serves you. You can then tear up the sheet or burn it in a safe place, such as in a fireproof container outdoors.
4. On a second, lovely sheet, write a letter to the woman you'll be in 90 days. Tell her what you wish for her, and put the letter in an envelope marked with the date on which you may open it.
5. Finally, place both hands on your heart, quietly thank yourself for everything you've done in these three months, and let the candle burn a little longer while you simply sit quietly with yourself.

What I feel after the ritual

Journal for week 13

What am I most grateful to myself for after these three months?

Which people in my life would I like to thank for their support?

What feeling am I taking with me into spring?

Which sentence would I like to stick on my mirror for the next 90 days?

I have unfolded, step by step, at my own pace. Movement begins with me, and I keep going.



My dear, we have three months behind us, and in them you've achieved so much more than you may be able to see right now. In winter you put down roots, you gave your buds space, and now, as spring begins, you've unfolded, with small, brave steps, with days full of momentum and with days on which you simply stayed kind to yourself. Thank you with all my heart for your trust, for your openness in our live calls and for every moment you took for yourself during this time. Please never forget that your ideas, your wishes and your needs matter just as much as those of everyone else in your life. Keep going at your own pace, celebrate every small step and come back again and again to your mat and to yourself, because movement begins with you. I'm endlessly proud of you and can't wait to hear about everything that blossoms in your spring. With love, Vivien

♡ Vivien